

Useful Open Source Software for Windows Developers

Gone are the days when developers had to struggle with a limited set of tools like Notepad for editing, and had to make do with comparing differences between software versions using the only tools available – their eyes and their intelligence. There are now many open source tools that enable a good software development experience on Windows. This article gives a brief on some of these.

While the UNIX environment has a large set of utilities that make some of the software development tasks easy, many developers do not have access to UNIX installation. Even though Linux is very popular today, it is still a hard decision for developers to opt for a dual boot system or move completely to a Linux environment. As a computer setup is still a costly affair, investing in multiple systems adds to the expense.

Over the years, many tools have been developed on Windows, and a lot of open source and free tools are also available now. These make the task of developers much easier. Many of the tools are now also visual in nature, which is a big relief, as command-line tools can be daunting.

Till a few years ago, there were very few choices in terms of tools available for development, as most of them needed a licence, and it was not possible for a developer to fork out forty thousand rupees for a Visual Studio licence – that too for the development of a personal project. The expansion of the open source ecosystem has been a liberating experience for most developers as we now have tools that allow us to perform many of the activities that needed expensive investments earlier. Having said that, as open source tools are developed by people, it will help the open source ecosystem if we donate for our favourite projects. Donations need not be monetary in nature. The best

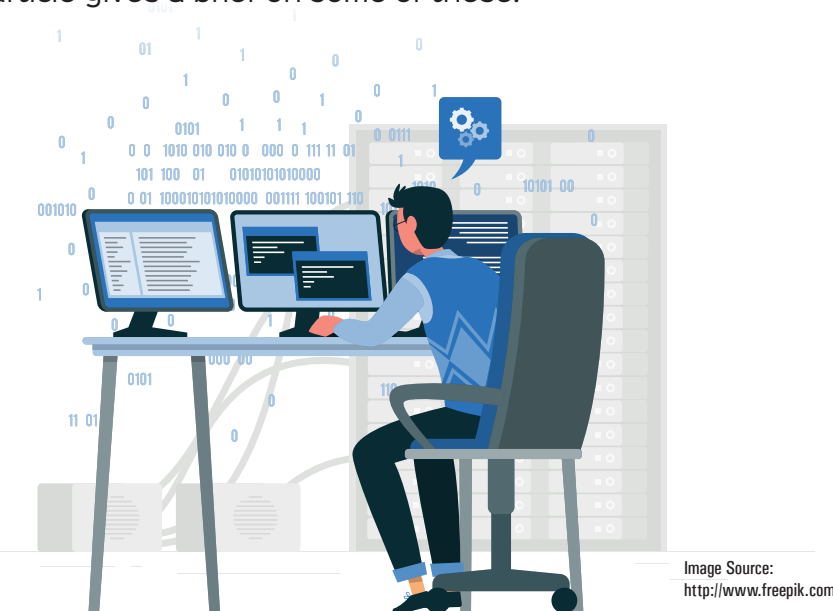


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donation for any open source project is to go through the code and improve the existing tool or add new features.

What do we need for software development?

For any development effort, we need a good and supportive editor, a method to compare versions of code files, a method to interact with a version control system for proper code management, a compiler, an assortment of libraries and an environment for deployment and testing. Most of us are aware of and use programming languages like Python and its associated libraries (too vast to list here). Similarly, we can use MySQL or PostgreSQL for storing data. While we can develop, deploy and test on the

local desktop or laptop, the same setup can be easily deployed to the cloud.

Recommended open source tools

Code editor

A fundamental need of any developer is to have a versatile editor at hand. When we discuss editors, one name immediately comes to mind — Notepad++. This feature-rich editor supports many of the activities required by a developer, and looks clean and elegant. One of its best features is that it allows us to open multiple documents in tabs. While this is a feature supported by most of today's editors, Notepad++ was one of the first to do so from a very early version. The editor supports syntax highlighting for many